



The PEACE Process

Phase 1, Week 9: Please *complete* this workbook before this week's group call

A Quick Review:

The 10 Pillars of Transformational Parenting:

1. Informed and Aware
2. Intentional and Reflective
3. Present, Committed, and Authentic
4. All Feelings are Valid and Welcome
5. Attuned and Empathetic
6. Loving Kindness and Forgiveness
7. Communicate to Connect and Understand
8. Nonviolence and Safety
9. Boundaries from Family Values
10. Joy, Play, and Fun!

ANCHOR for Self-Regulation:

- Awareness of body
- Name what is happening in your body
- Connect to your sensory calming tool
- Honor the process
- Open to connection
- Recommit to your child

HARBOR for Co-Regulation:

- Hold space
- Accept what is
- Remember sensory calming tools
- Be low, slow and soft
- Open to connection
- Remind child of safety

Recipe For a Meaningful Repair

- Connect
- Ask consent
- I imagine that you're feeling _____
- Because of my choice to _____
- I regret how I _____, because it caused you to _____
- In the future, I'll do my best to _____
- For now, would it support you if _____

Self-Apology for Inner Safety

- Name what happened.
- Name how you feel about what happened.
- Name what you felt before you reacted.
- Name what need was not being met for you.
- Name how your mistake impacted your child (feelings and needs).
- Make a commitment for next time.
- Forgive. Let yourself know that you deserve forgiveness, and ruptures are an opportunity to reconnect.

Sensory Calming Access Tools

- Vision
- Movement
- Sound
- Taste
- Touch

Root-to-Bloom Process for Looking Beneath the Surface of Behavior

- FLOWER: Outward expression of the child's behavior.
- ROOTS: Everything beneath the surface that the parent must pause and take into consideration:
 - Feelings → Beliefs → Nervous system regulation
 - Unmet needs → Context of situation → Quality of secure attachment
 - Thoughts → Brain development

Process of Emotion Coaching Our Children (SOOTHE):

- S: Sink into your ANCHOR
- O: Open your HARBOR
- O: Offer empathy & validation
- T: Tools for sensory calming
- H: Hear your child
- E: Explore options for the future

Embodied Empathy and Emotional Intelligence (FEEL):

- F: Focus on the physical sensation of the feeling.
- E: Embrace this moment as a "temporary teacher," here to communicate.
- E: Expand into the left brain: invite 3 feeling words.
- L: Label the need(s)



The 10 Steps of an Empowered Conversation:

- | | | |
|----------------|-----------------------|------------------|
| 1. Connect | 5. Concern | 9. Clear request |
| 2. Consent | 6. Responsibility | 10. Appreciation |
| 3. Intention | 7. Feelings and needs | |
| 4. Affirmation | 8. Empathy | |

- I. *How are you integrating the above frameworks into your heart, mind, body, and relationship with your child? Is there anywhere you're getting stuck?*

(Remember, this is a process and a practice — it takes time!)

The PEACE Process

Discipline rooted in benevolent leadership, generous assumption, and boundaries created through shared family values. Thus far in your Transformational Parenting journey, we have laid the foundation of: the basic framework of Transformational Parenting, attachment, nervous system, brain, and emotional science, and nonviolent communication.

We've spent time unpacking and integrating these foundational frameworks, which address the head, heart, and hands of Transformational Parenting in order to move into the essence: the PEACE Process.

What Is The PEACE Process?

A five-step framework to replace disciplinary strategies of power over or under parenting. With the PEACE Process, our world no longer needs strategies to achieve harmony in a home such as:

- Threats to control a child's behavior
- Fear-based obedience
- Manipulation via bribes or rewards for desired behavior
- Spanking, pinching, swatting, slapping
- Punitive consequences to "teach our child a lesson"
- Parenting from fear
- Parenting with helplessness and despair
- Timeouts or shame corners
- Power struggles out of desperation
- Lying and secrets

Why The PEACE Process?

We use the PEACE process as our main plan of action or response map in any given parenting scenario because we value:

- Connection over correction
- Relationship longevity over immediate gratification
- Equality and mutual respect
- Communication over coercion
- Collaboration over "parent knows best"



When Do We Use The PEACE Process?

As a parent, grandparent, or child-care provider, you can use the PEACE Process in literally every parent-child scenario. Yes, literally every one!

We all need a framework for HOW to respond to challenging moments like:

- Sibling squabbles
- Child not following through with an agreement
- Child struggling to honor the family boundaries
- Behavior from child (or parent!) that results in harm of any kind
- The family struggling to work as a team
- Parent and child disagreeing and getting stuck in power struggle
- Conflict resolution

How Does The PEACE Process Work?

The PEACE Process is broken down into five intentional phases. They can be used individually in any given parenting scenario where a response is necessary, or used as an entire formula. This formula, or “recipe,” is rooted in all 10 Pillars of Transformational Parenting, and breathes life into every Transformational Parenting framework you have learned thus far. This is Transformational Parenting brought to actualization. This is Transformational Parenting LIVING its core values, and therefore honoring its boundaries. *(More on this soon!)*

Let’s go step-by-step through this revolutionary process. Remember as you go: get comfortable, anchor yourself into inner safety, and engage an expansive belief like: “Anything is possible” or “I am capable of learning new things.”

The 5-Step PEACE Process for responding to any parenting scenario:

1. Presence
2. Empathy
3. Acknowledge what is true
4. Conscious communication
5. Exploring solutions together

In the following sections, we’ll work through each of these five steps.



Step 1: Presence

We live in a disconnected world, even on occasion disconnected from ourselves. Most of us spend most of the time in a reverie of our thoughts, feelings and distractions. The practice (and it is a practice!) of PRESENCE allows us to be with our children FULLY, so we can meet them in the now, and create new ways of relating, problem-solving and cooperation. Before responding to ANY parenting situation, take as little as three seconds (if the response requires immediate attention) to ground into your Anchor. Get as present as possible. When you approach a parenting scenario NOT fully present, rooted in your body and internal safety, you could easily escalate the entire scenario.

You can communicate to your child that, "I am coming to help you, but I need to get a drink of water first." If that is not possible and an IMMEDIATE response is required, in instances of threatened safety or real danger, then you can communicate to your child that *"I am not fully present to help you in this moment, but I am going to work on becoming present while I'm here."*

You are NOT expected to be perfectly present every time you are needed to respond in your parenting. You don't have to model perfection, you get to model the process. You get to show your child that *"even I struggle getting present sometimes, and I am still committed to my process."*

- II. *What is your sensory calming tool? How do you become present in times of stress?*

- III. *What is your child's sensory calming tool (in addition to your safe presence)?*

- IV. *Can you recall a time when you were needed to respond to a situation when you allowed yourself time to pause and gain presence before responding?*



Step 2: Empathy and Emotional Connection

After presence has been established, we get to connect our right brain to our child's right brain. We get to connect to feelings and needs. We have no need to FIX, CHANGE, or SAVE our children from their feelings, their conflicts, or their growth moments. From presence and inner safety, we can simply BE with our children, and ourselves in our emotions, feelings, and needs.

Practice the FEEL framework. We can name and identify feelings and needs without jumping into solutions. "Feel it to heal it" and "name it to tame it."

There are so many benefits of cultivating empathy in your relationships. When you can give and receive empathy, each person you show up for feels a deep sense of being heard. When one knows that they can be heard, defensiveness eases and connection becomes possible. Empathy contributes to healthy differentiation, as well as emotional security. With empathy, you can be a true companion and support another person without taking on their struggles as your own. However, when we mistakenly use methods of communication that do not come from a place of true empathy, we miss an opportunity to see, hear, and understand the other person in their experience.

What Is Not Empathy?

The following responses are what you might offer to someone's expression of emotion or difficulty. Although they will meet an individual's needs, they are not examples of true empathy, which is what an individual seeks before their needs are met. Ideally, we can practice being conscious of the following habitual responses and instead of following through with them we can ask the speaker how they would like to be supported when they share something with us.

Sympathy:

- Bring attention back to yourself. *"Oh, I am so sorry, I feel terrible for you."*

Advice:

- You assume the other person wants to know what you think they should do. *"Well, what you could do is..."*
- This may meet a need for support after empathy is received.



Explain/Analyze:

- You believe that if you tell someone why they feel the way they do, they will feel better. *"You just feel bad because ... "*
- This may meet a need for clarity after the need for empathy is met.

Correct:

- You try to point out someone's mistake in interpreting. *"He didn't do that to hurt you, it was an accident."*
- This may meet a need for groundedness after the need for empathy is met.

Console:

- *"It will be okay. You're okay, everything will work out."*
- This may meet a need for emotional regulation.

Tell A Story:

- *"The same thing happened to me. This one time ..."*
- This may meet a need for acceptance or belonging.

Push Away Feelings:

- You might be uncomfortable so you tell others not to feel what they feel. *"Come on smile, don't be sad.", "Just calm down and take a deep breath.", or "It's not that big of a deal, just let it go."*
- This typically does not meet any needs.

Investigate/Interrogate:

- *"Why did you do that? What made you feel that way?"*
- This may meet a need for clarity after the need for empathy is met, but typically this is about the listener's need for clarity and information and arises out of anxiety. Questioning *why* a person did something puts them on the defensive.

Evaluate:

- You decide if another's emotional response is appropriate or not. *"You are overreacting. This is no big deal."*
- This typically doesn't meet any needs. All emotional responses are inherently valid because they are part of the human experience.

Educate:

- *"What I see about the situation is ... The reason you feel like that is..."*
- This may meet a need for learning and support after the need for empathy is met.



One-Up:

- *"That's awful, but something even worse happened to me and I was devastated."*
- This typically doesn't meet any needs.

Diagnose:

- *"Sounds like you just need more sleep. Let's have you go to bed early tonight."*
- This may meet a need for learning and support if it is consent based and offered after the need for empathy is met.

Demand:

- *"If you don't get control of your emotions, I'm leaving!"*
- This typically doesn't meet any needs.

Denial Of Choice:

- *"It's a hard thing, but we all have to do it."*
- This typically doesn't meet any needs.

Nod & Smile:

- You feel uncomfortable and just want to get out of the situation. Or you lose track of yourself and become completely lost in the experience of the other person.
- This typically doesn't meet any needs.

Collusion:

- You agree and add to judgments and blame. *"You're right he really is a jerk!"*
- This may meet a need for support or being seen/heard in the moment, but then escalates or entrenches reactivity.

Silver Lining:

- Move past what's happening toward some possible positive outcome. *"You will learn so much from this experience!"; "That person wasn't a good friend for you anyway."*
- This may meet a need for encouragement or hope, after the need for empathy is met.

Cheerleading:

- You assume the need is for hope or reassurance. *"You're a strong person, you can get through this."; "You've been through worse and made it."; "I believe in you."*
- This may meet a need for encouragement or hope, after the need for empathy is met.



Step 3: Acknowledge What Is True

From presence and right-brain connection, we then get to connect to the left brain. We get to ignite our thinking brain and practice mindsight, in both ourselves and in service to our child. Part of giving empathy to yourself is being very honest with yourself about your feelings at that moment. They may not be those thoughts or feelings that you want to act on like, *"This kid is driving me crazy! I just want to leave!"*

Don't edit these thoughts or feelings. It's important to acknowledge them, no matter the situation. If you judge or try to suppress your thoughts or feelings, they could emerge later, possibly in not the healthiest ways. Telling yourself *"I shouldn't be this angry"* makes your emotion STRONGER! What we resist persists and strengthens.

Separate your feelings from your interpretations.

On the next page you will find a list of words that we often mistakenly categorize as feelings when in fact, they would be more accurately described as interpretations. We first looked at these "faux feelings" in Week 7.

For example, if someone forgets your birthday you could say that you felt unloved, when your true feelings may have been anger, sadness, or even disappointment. But to say that you felt unloved makes an assumption about the other person's feelings behind that action: not loving you. When we use this language, it can often trigger defensiveness in the listener and digress from a genuine feeling, becoming more of a mental projection.

Regardless of these interpretations being accurate or inaccurate, continuing to use this inaccurate language can make the distinctions between feelings and interpretations blurred. This habit can remove us from a place of empathy and bring us into a place of emotionally-fueled assumptions, causing us to draw highly inaccurate conclusions.

Interpretations often...

- Have an "un" or "mis" at the beginning or an "ed" at the end
- Require the action of someone else
- Trigger defensiveness in your listener

Behind each of these words are precious feelings and needs.



- V. Circle three words you have used recently and name the feelings and needs present for you while you have used each word.

Abandoned	Unloved	Unappreciated	Unheard
Belittled	Used	Unsupported	Unwanted
Confined	Left out	Violated	Wronged
Discounted	Bullied	Attacked	Victimized
Harassed	Overpowered	Criticized	Tricked
Intimidated	Put down	Dumped on	Unseen
Judged	Taken advantage of	Interrupted	Alienated
Neglected	Coerced	Isolated	Blamed
Provoked	Disrespected	Misunderstood	Patronized
Smothered	Insulted	Pressured	Rejected
Trampled	Invisible	Threatened	Manipulated

Make Neutral Observations vs. Evaluations:

Observations: Name only what you see and hear in an objective way, as if through the lens of a video recorder, or a sportscaster..

- *"I see your clothes are on the floor."*
- *"You are on your phone past our agreed upon time."*
- *"I found your shoes outside in the yard."*

Evaluations, interpretations, and criticism: These are statements made with a very thick filter on what is actually true. It typically puts you into a *"my child is doing this TO ME"* place, and puts the child into a *"THEY are doing this to me"* position. It's inherently separating.

- *"You are so messy and disorganized. I wish you would clean your room for once in your life."*
- *"You're being so disrespectful right now. Give that phone to me. I give an inch and you take a mile."*
- *"I found your shoes outside AGAIN. Why can't you simply pick up your shoes and bring them inside?"*



Remember the root-to-bloom process and look UNDER the behavior of your child.

What is true is that your child's behavior and capacity for conflict resolution is an expression of several things: the state of their nervous system, the quality of security within their attachment to you as their care provider, their brain development, their emotional intelligence, and their capacity to communicate while stressed.

Remember the *Ages and Stages**

*Excerpt from *The Soul of Discipline* by Kim John Payne

Around 2 years old: The little emperor

They are waking up to the world around them and discovering their own willpower and feeling a sense of "I am almighty and the only one in the universe." Pushing boundaries is a normal milestone. They want to understand WHY!? They are longing to understand how the world works, how relationships work.

Around 5 years old: "You're no boss of me!"

They push away from the motherly fold, wanting to do things their own way, yet still needing a lot of help.

Around 9 years old: On the cusp

They are leaving early childhood behind but are not yet fully in middle childhood. This phase is characterized by insecurities and pushback against family rules.

Around 13 years old: The Huck Finn and Pippi Longstocking years

They are experiencing all the well-known hormonal changes, but it is also the age of breakout and discovery.

Around 16 years old: Closed for reconstruction

A lot of energy goes inward as they try to work out who they are. While they are hypersensitive and emotionally raw, they are also capable of spectacular intensity toward others. They have so many decisions to make, and new responsibilities to consider, yet still want to have fun and be free. They may seem to "regress" to needing co-regulation like they did as toddlers or in early childhood, but may seem confused by their longing to be close, and a simultaneous longing to push away.



Step 4: Conscious Communication

"When your internal dialogue is centered in a language of life, you will be able to focus your attention on the actions you could take to manifest a situation that meets your needs along with those of others." - Dr. Marshall B. Rosenberg, PhD.

So far in the PEACE Process, we have mindfully named and consciously communicated:

- Our feelings and needs with clarity and self-responsibility.
- The child's feelings and needs with empathy (remember, this comes AFTER safety has been established and the communication brain is back "online").
- What is true about the current circumstances based on an objective viewpoint.
- The need to give space to each child to tell their version of the story; to allow each child a chance to be fully heard and understood.
- The importance of reflecting what you hear your child saying and asking clarifying questions without judgment. We want to model how to speak from self-responsibility and how to make neutral observations instead of interpretations.

Magical phrases during conflict resolution:

- Tell me more: *"Drey, I hear you say that Lana was being mean and calling you rude names, and your body felt so angry, that your hands grabbed her iPad. Tell me more about that."*
- Is it true that...?: *"Lana, is it true that you called Drey names? I wonder what you must have been feeling to say those words to him?"*
- Am I getting this right?: *"So, it sounds like you two were struggling with big strong feelings and you were not sure how to navigate this in a safe way, is that right?"*

Next, we shift into addressing the situation at hand by naming and facilitating mutually beneficial outcomes for all parties involved.



Step 5: Exploring Solutions Together

These are the concrete actions you'd like family members to take. Invite your child to explore a solution TOGETHER with you. Collaboration is the goal so we can maintain social engagement within the relationship. Any behavior correction approach (threats, bribes, punishments, rewards) risks pushing the child into fight (aggression), flight (shut down or freeze), or fawn (pleasing others against their true needs and desires) responses.

These solutions are rooted in:

- Shared and previously agreed upon family values
- A belief that everyone's needs in the family are equal
- A belief that anything is possible
- A belief that the parent is a safe space and here to guide the child through conflict with capability

These solutions are:

- Reminders of what the family values most
- Flexible when possible, non-negotiable when safety is concerned
- Consistent without rigidity
- NOT stuck on strategies (See below)

For children under 7:

The parent may have the solution in mind and is facilitating the child to find their way there on their own. They stand sturdy in the family value, while supporting the child through their resistance or rejection of the boundary or solution. This allows the children to be a part of the process, while rooted in the safety and sturdiness of a benevolent leader.

Example scenario:

Parent:	<i>"I would love to see us working together as a team here. How do you think we could make this happen? We could all play outside on the trampoline, or we could nestle in for some book reading."</i>
Child's objection:	<i>"I don't want to do either of those! I don't want to work as a team!"</i>
Parent (meeting the objection):	<i>"We need to get this playroom tidied up before dinner. I'm really glad we were able to hear each other. Suz, what would you like to clean up, the dolls or the blocks? Lily, would you like to help daddy tidy up the cars, or the play kitchen?"</i>



	OR: <i>"Ok."</i> (Silence, presence. Maybe a hug, or getting low to the ground.) <i>"Sounds like you may not be ready to work as a team right now. Let's relax here for a bit until your body feels ready enough. Take your time. I'm here as your safe place."</i> (Pause) <i>"I am ready to help you work as a team when you are."</i>
Child's objection:	<i>"NO! I hate cleaning up blocks. I always have to clean up the blocks and Lily gets to do whatever she wants to!"</i>
Parent (meeting the objection):	<i>"Mmmm."</i> (Soft face, soft gaze, warm tone) <i>"It's hard to feel stuck in one job. Sounds like you'd like something new and different? How about...(silence)...hmmm...do you have any ideas? I believe we can work this out in a way that feels right for you."</i>

For children between 7 and 12:

Ideally, the family has crystal clear values that the child has witnessed being modeled for years now. The parent is still the benevolent leader, with a lot more spaciousness as to how the family value is honored. The boundaries and solutions are more flexible and creative. The parent can present more than two options at a time and invite the child to expand upon the options. The parent remains the "safe space" and will let the child know if their proposed solution misaligns with family values or does not consider the needs of the entire family. Remember, the brain here is still learning how to create solutions that involve an extensive amount of thought and understanding of natural consequence. If family values are just being introduced, and they have been raised in the "power over" solution process, then they may be in the 0-7 solution process category.

Example statements:

- *"It sounds like you two need to come to an agreement around this."*
- *"It sounds like we need to figure out a solution to this problem together. Remember our family values of integrity and communication. I trust you to be creative and I'll be here to facilitate."*

For children 13 and older:

At this age, they are coming into their own values, and may sway between embracing the family values and rebelling against them. Even in the most secure of attachments, children of this age are exploring whether they personally feel in integrity with the family values.

If family values are just now being introduced, they may be more in the phase of the 0-7 year old, who needs very grounded and supportive modeling from the parent, with only a couple of choices that work well for the whole family.

Example scenario:

Parent:	<i>"I am deeply longing for your safety. When you don't answer your phone after dark, I am super uncomfortable. My idea of a solution is for you to be home before dark while we work on an agreement we both trust will work for us. What's your idea?"</i>
Teen:	<i>"I honestly forget to turn my ringer up. I promise I'm safe. My idea is that before I leave the house, we make sure my ringer is up as loud as it can be."</i>
Parent:	<i>"I am willing to try that once, and if you do not answer your phone after that idea, then we need to re-work this."</i>
Teen:	<i>"Okay, that sounds good to me."</i>



Your Personal Values

In order to successfully explore solutions with a child of any age, we must be rooted and securely attached to our family values. In this next exercise you should be looking to define the things that are important to you. You don't have to think about this too much. It is usually fairly accurate to quickly identify the values that resonate with you, move you, and jump out at you.

NOTE: Be honest. Don't select something (or not) because you feel it is something that you "should" or "shouldn't" value.

VI. *Circle or mark 10 values that you feel are most important in your life today. You may hold some values that are not on this list; feel free to add your own.*

Accomplishment	Efficiency	Kindness	Romance
Accountability	Enjoyment	Knowledge	Rule of Law
Accuracy	Equality	Leadership	Safety
Adventure	Excellence	Love	Satisfying Others
All for One and One for All	Fairness	Loyalty	Security
Beauty	Faith	Meaning	Self-Givingness
Calm	Faithfulness	Merit	Self-Thinking
Challenge	Family	Money	Sensitivity
Change	Flair	Oneness	Service (to others, society)
Charity	Freedom	Openness	Simplicity
Cleanliness	Friendship	Other's Point of View	Skill
Collaboration	Fun	Patriotism	Speed
Commitment	Generosity	Peace	Spirit
Communication	Gentleness	Nonviolence	Spirituality
Community	Global View	Perfection	Stability
Competence	Goodwill	Personal Growth	Standardization
Competition	Goodness	Perseverance	Status
Concern for Others	Gratitude	Pleasure	Strength
	Hard Work		



Connection	Happiness	Power	Success
Continuous Improvement	Harmony	Preservation	Failing Forward
Cooperation	Health	Privacy	Systemization
Coordination	Honor	Progress	Teamwork
Creativity	Human-Centered	Prosperity	Timeliness
Decisiveness	Improvement	Punctuality	Tolerance
Determination	Independence	Quality of Work	Tradition
Delight of Being	Individuality	Quiet	Tranquility
Democracy	Inner Peace	Regularity	Trust
Discipline	Innovation	Reliability	Truth
Discovery	Integrity	Resourcefulness	Unity
Diversity	Intelligence	Respect for Others	Variety
Dynamism	Intensity	Responsiveness	Wealth
	Justice	Results-Oriented	Well Being

VII. *Now simplify! Choose your top 10 values, and highlight your top three. Write each of these below, starting with the three that are most important to you:*

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____



Your Personal Strengths

Understanding your personal strengths will give you more clarity around your authentic values, and the values that you want to model to your children. This will also allow you to understand your child's authentic values and have more awareness if YOU, as the parent, are honoring their boundaries as well. Take a moment to go through this list of personal strengths. As you read, make a note about which personal strengths stand out as being yours and which ones are your child's strengths. (This is based on research by psychologists Christopher Peterson and Martin Seligman in their book, *Character Strengths and Virtues*.)

Personal Strengths of Courage

Bravery: Do you readily go where angels fear to tread? When everyone is holding back, are you the one who stands up to volunteer with words like “what the heck” or “you never know until you try?”

Persistence: When others are ready to quit, are you the one who encourages them to try just one more time? Have you doggedly worked at a problem until you find the solution instead of giving up or passing the problem on to someone else?

Integrity: Have you ever told the truth knowing that it would cost you money, friends, and perhaps your reputation? Do you do the “right” thing all the time, even when no one is watching?

Vitality: Do you inject energy into the projects you're involved in? Do things seem to somehow pick up speed when you are around? Do people give more of themselves when you are working alongside them?

Personal Strengths of Humanity

Love: When you look at people, do you see what they look like or do you see who they really are? Do you feel a deep appreciation for everyone you meet because each individual is unique and special?



Kindness: Are you incapable of walking past a street busker without dropping a few notes or coins into his box? Have you done good deeds for strangers on a regular basis because you saw the difficult situations they were in?

Social Intelligence: Can you sense the mood of people in the room the moment you walk into it? Are you able to tell who gets along and who does not after a quick observation? Do people readily “click” with you even when they don’t get along with each other?

Personal Strengths of Justice

Citizenship: Are you proud to be a member of an organization or nation? Are you an ambassador for your company or country? Is loyalty to this group very important to you?

Fairness: Were you the child who kept saying “that’s not fair?” Have you given up your share of something because you felt it was not right that other people didn’t have the same privilege? Do you see everyone as having equal rights?

Leadership: Do people look to you for guidance in chaos or in general? Does a group seem to gel only when you’re there to hold it together? Do those in your group excel under your tutelage when they weren’t making it elsewhere?

Personal Strengths of Temperance

Forgiveness: Are you able to let go when people have repeatedly hurt you? Do you understand that harboring a grudge hurts you more than it hurts them? Do you accept the frailty of human nature and allow people space to make mistakes?

Humility: Do you constantly learn from other people, even those who are younger or less educated or experienced than you? Can you accept praise graciously while not taking personal credit and walking on air immediately after?

Prudence: When given two options, do you usually choose the less risky, less expensive, less high-profile one? Do you tend to view others’ excesses as flamboyant or extravagant, and often advise people to tone things down?



Personal Strengths of Wisdom and Knowledge

Creativity: Do people come to you for novel solutions to tricky problems? Do you enjoy seeking alternative ways of doing things? Is your mind constantly challenging the status quo and looking for a better way?

Curiosity: Do you ask lots of questions and stop only when the other person is obviously tired of answering? Have you had your fair share of accidents and injuries because you just had to try something out?

Open-Mindedness: Are you able to hold two contradictory thoughts at the same time while others are taking sides? When presented with a radical idea, do you consider it a possibility instead of judging it right away?

Love of Learning: Is there always a book in your bag so you can pull it out to read when you have a few spare minutes? Do you get an adrenaline rush from learning new skills or attending classes or seminars?

Perspective: Can you see things from different points of view without making a conscious effort to? Do people tend to respond to your thoughtful comments with “I never saw things that way...?”

Personal Strengths of Transcendence

Appreciation of Beauty: Do you pause often to take in a view, gaze skywards, or observe animals in motion? Does a sense of awe sweep over you often when you contemplate the vastness of nature and the intimate details of life?

Gratitude: Are the words “thank you” on your lips and in your heart practically every day? Is your reaction to people, events, and things one of appreciation and gladness that this wonderful thing came your way?

Hope: Can you always see the silver lining when others see only a dark cloud? Is your mantra “tomorrow will be better than today” or “don’t worry, everything will be ok” or “things will work out, you’ll see?”



Humor: Can you see the lighter side of almost every situation? Do you see the folly of human self-importance? Do people relax around you because you help them take themselves and life less seriously?

Spirituality: Do you feel connected to a source that is higher and deeper than yourself? Are you detached from things of this world? Do you feel that the “real” world is inside you rather than outside?

Shortlist Your Personal Strengths

You may feel that many of these strengths apply to you. You will want to take some time with them. Ask your friends and family what they see as your strengths. Take a moment now to list 3 to 5 of your and your child’s personal strengths below.

VIII. *My top FIVE individual strengths are:*

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

IX. *My child's top FIVE individual strengths are:*

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____



Establishing Boundaries or Limits from Family Values

The whole energy around establishing boundaries is to connect and cooperate with your child. We're not enforcing anything, we are providing a structure.

We are trusting that our children will learn our family limits over time, with lots and lots of practice and empathy. Your child may not like the boundary or limit you set and will need to release feelings. Your job is to be the emotional coach, to be present and support your child with empathy. This does not mean changing your boundary in any way if you are confident, clear, and secure in its expression, especially in regard to your child's safety.

You can shift HOW you're going to HONOR this boundary, but not the actual boundary.

Example: The boundary is "Our family eats dinner together every weeknight."

The value it's rooted in: Connection

The possible strategies to honor this value and uphold the boundary:

- Dinner on a picnic blanket in the living room.
- Eating around the table while one person reads aloud a story to keep young children's attention.
- Young child can stand and move around during dinner in order to tend to their sensory needs and stay focused.
- Dinner happens and the child can choose to EAT or, they can choose to simply be in the room, and wait to eat until their body says they are hungry.
- The family eats at a time that works for everyone's hunger, not just the parents.
- The family prioritizes NO evening activities or playdates so the children are not too tired to engage in a family activity.
- The parent makes sure the meal consists of foods that appeal to the child, while also providing new options. (Many children who struggle with limited food options would greatly benefit from an occupational therapist, this is usually sensory-processing related.)
- Dinner happens at the family table while some kids chat and some kids work on homework.



See how this works? As adults, we want to show our children that our boundaries are precious, even sacred. AND, that we are not stuck on the strategy as to how this boundary occurs. We are willing to be flexible and creative.

As the adult, you may believe you should determine how a boundary is followed, especially if you were not allowed to participate in negotiations or collaboration around family boundaries and limits as a kid.

The value beneath the boundary or limit is the reason why you are committed to this boundary, and committed to the negotiation process. Children need to feel safe and protected as they grow. And they need to feel that they have the container of safety.

Clear boundaries create an environment of support around a child within which they can explore and engage with themselves, others and the world.

Your environment of support includes:

- Daily routines
- Supportive belief systems
- Clear boundaries according to family values
- Conscious and connected communication

What are boundaries? Boundaries are:

- Consciously planned with family values in mind.
- Consciously established with an understanding of developmentally appropriate expectations of a child's mental, physical, and spiritual development.

X. *What are your "non-negotiable family boundaries?"*

(Example: In our home, we respect each other's bodies and we do not hit.)

XI. *How do you typically respond when your child crosses this boundary?*

XII. *If your child is under the age of 7, do you set boundaries and have expectations for your child to follow said boundaries? Do you hold the awareness that these children are still very undeveloped in their ability to think through the consequences of their actions?*

XIII. *How can you imagine responding to a conflict, sibling squabble or dishonoring of family boundary or limit with the PEACE Process?*

Example: Young boy hits his older sister.

P	Parent eliminates distractions if possible and goes immediately to the child in need. A conscious presence is in the parent's mind, even if they are not perfectly regulated and calm. While the parent stands or kneels in front of the child, they are focusing on slowing down their heart rate by deep exhalations. The child feels this, too, and their nervous system mirrors the parent's and begins to find calm again.
E	Parent notices their body, and their feelings. Maybe they can connect these to a need as well, but maybe not. The parent chooses to voice these out loud: → <i>"I am here to help you two. And, I'm feeling rather tense in my body and frustrated in my heart because I was really hoping to focus on fixing dinner. Help me understand what's going on. Dani, you seem pretty upset and stressed, and Dean, you seem pretty angry. Who wants to go first?"</i>
A	The parent accepts that the child needs them at this moment and trusts that whatever is on the to-do list will be accomplished. Parent checks any judgments, fear-based thoughts, or limiting beliefs coming up about themselves or their children. <i>They ground into what IS true: We are safe, we are capable, we can get through this together.</i>
C	The parent communicates consciously and compassionately, understanding that their words "become their child's inner voice." → Parent: <i>"Dani, I imagine you feel hurt and a bit frustrated that Dean hit you. I'm guessing he moved pretty fast and you didn't have time to do anything different?"</i> (Shows empathy with face, pays attention to child's body language, checks in with self: should I keep talking, or should I pause and allow the child to verbally process?) → Dani: <i>"Ya, he always hits me if he doesn't get his way! He just wants to make me cry! You let us play alone even though you know he's so mean to me."</i>

- **Parent:** *"Ohhh, I can see how you might feel afraid playing alone. It does seem like a big responsibility for you to take care of the situation without help. I want to hear Dean's side too, and I'll come back to hear your ideas."*
- **Parent to Dean:** *"Dean I can see in your face that you still have a lot of anger. Let's keep getting that out..."* Checks in with self: Would words be helpful here? Or co-regulation through arm squeezing or stomping? Would letting Dean be in his anger be enough for right now?
- If the parent DOES decide to speak, they might say *"I see you, Dean. We're going to get through this. Full permission to be upset and angry. I'm capable of holding space for you. Tell me about what happened just now..."*
- **Dean:** *"She didn't share with me!"*
- **Parent:** *"I hear how much you were wanting to play with her toys."*

E

The parent checks in with both Dean and Dani to explore solutions together. (This may even occur later that night while tucking each child into bed, when everyone is very relaxed and open to sharing.)

- *Dean, I heard your voice shouting, and I think that was a clue you were getting angry. Can you give any ideas of what to do when you first start feeling angry?*
- *Hmm, ok... What if you shout really loud "Mommy! I'm so angry and I can't stop!" Then I can come closer to see what's happening to help before your fists take the anger and hit Dani. What do you think?*
- *Dani, do you remember that Dean is still very young and his body moves so much faster than his brain? I wonder if you have ideas about what to do when you see Dean starting to get angry and I'm not with you?*

Practice the PEACE Process

XIV. Recall a parenting scenario with your child that required a peaceful, collaborative response:

What was the boundary?

--

What was the value?

--

P	
E	



A

C

E



Permanent vs. Evolving Boundaries

Many parents struggle to understand when to negotiate the boundary and when to stand firm. Oftentimes, the easiest way to navigate this is to ask this question: *“Will I always feel this way or might my feelings change over time?”* If the feeling is very clearly going to remain static over time, it is a **permanent boundary**. There is usually a lot of clarity for the adult in these boundaries.

Examples: “Under no circumstances will my child ever be able to use illegal substances in my home.” Or, “A child causing physical harm to someone else is never acceptable.”

When an adult lovingly sets these limits, the child may have big feelings about them. In this instance, the adult can hold space for their feelings, help the child feel heard and seen, and collaboratively discuss alternatives with the child.

The collaboration isn't in the boundary, but rather, in the workable and mutually agreeable alternatives, whatever they may be. Conversely, an **evolving boundary** is one that is likely to change over time. Most parenting boundaries evolve.

Examples: “My child is too young to go to the playground without an adult, but they will be able to go with just their friends when they're older.” Or, “My child can't set their own bedtime yet, but when they're [x years old], I'll offer them more flexibility as long as they get enough rest overall.”

When an adult lovingly sets these limits, it's often with an air of *“This is our plan for now.”* It's not intended to be, or expressed as being, permanent, and yet we can have respectful firmness in the boundary for the current situation.

Oftentimes, the adult might hold space for the child's perspective by saying something like, *“I hear how much you want x. For now, this is our plan. I will let you know if and when we can revisit it.”* At this point, as with the permanent boundary, the adult can validate feelings and collaborate about alternatives. The adult may also offer some flexibility within the boundary, if appropriate.

For example, the adult might still have a set bedtime for the child but is willing to make exceptions for certain occasions to see how it goes. Note that this doesn't make the adult “wishy washy.” To the contrary, it makes them flexible and reinforces the benefits of exploring caregiving with a lens of curiosity.



And, of course, if the child raises a perspective that the adult hadn't considered and it seems like a reasonable solution, it models wonderful flexibility to say, *"You know what? I hadn't thought of it that way. Thank you. Let's try that and see how it goes."* Some boundaries can evolve "in the moment" and show the child that the adult values their input. It helps the child feel seen, even if it's not a permanent alteration to the boundary.

Finally, it's important to note that for evolving boundaries, if the child is very young, stating that the boundary might be flexible "someday" could be confusing, disconcerting, and/or frustrating for the child. With young children, simple and direct answers are usually best.

Evolving boundaries allow adults to feel less rigidity in their parenting. Less rigidity naturally lends itself to fewer power struggles over time. Leading with confidence, for both permanent and evolving boundaries, is beneficial regardless of the child's age.



Navigating Natural and Logical Consequences

Conscious parenting is not parenting devoid of consequences. Rather, it's devoid of arbitrary and unilaterally adult-imposed consequences ("punishments" or "loss of privileges").

With **natural consequences**, the adult (within safety limits) allows the child to learn through their experience, even if the outcome is perhaps undesirable. The result of the action in and of itself is the "teacher" that helps the child understand the results of their actions (or lack thereof).

Example: A child is refusing to study for an upcoming test because they're too busy chatting online with a friend. Rather than force the studying, or grounding the child and making them cease social contact for the time being, the adult allows the child to get a less-than-stellar grade on the test. The adult will, all the while and certainly after the grade is received, work with the child to find the root cause of their lack of interest in studying. Is the material too boring or too hard? Is the child lonely and really needing social contact to help them feel "seen?" Is the child being bullied? Something else? The adult gets curious rather than punishing and further alienating the child.

A natural consequence is usually the most effective teacher. It works particularly well if the adult is lovingly supportive of the child as they process what happened. The adult refrains from blaming and shaming, and instead, works with the child to guide them to a better path forward. With **logical consequences**, the adult does "direct" the outcome, albeit not in a punitive way.

Example: A child wants to ride their bike without a helmet. If the adult feels a helmet is important and non-negotiable, the adult may set a boundary and require the helmet for access to the bike. If the child goes biking without the helmet anyway, the adult might remove access to the bike.

Different from a threat or a punishment, the adult describes the consequence with lovingkindness, making sure to hear the child's perspective. Once again, the adult approaches the situation from a state of curiosity. In this example, is the child's helmet uncomfortable? Too hot? Is the chin strap too tight? Perhaps there's an easy solution. With both natural and logical consequences, the adult supports the child as life teaches the child its most valuable lessons.



Summary

Takeaways:

- **The PEACE process is a discipline framework** rooted in benevolent leadership, generous assumptions, recognition of development stages, and boundaries from explicit values. It negates the need for any strategy based in power over or under parenting (punishments, rewards, threats, bribes, permissiveness, manipulation, or coercion, etc.)
- **The framework can be used in any parenting scenario** when conflict arises between children, between a child and parent, or among the entire family.
- **Presence:** self-regulation, co-regulation (even imperfectly)
- **Empathy:** FEEL into self-empathy, avoid common misconceptions of empathy
- **Acknowledge what is true:** accept your reactive thoughts and separate your perceptions, evaluations, and interpretations from neutral observations; use Mindsight to get deeper understanding of the other person's experience
- **Conscious communication:** active listening, reflective listening, open questions to gather more details and understanding
- **Exploring solutions together:** taking your child's age and development into consideration, co-create boundaries based on values with flexibility in how your child honors them; recognize your permanent boundaries and evolving boundaries

Invitation to Practice:

- **Reflect on a recent conflict** that did not play out as you hoped (noting the use of any punitive or arbitrary consequences). Rewrite your ideal version of the scenario, identifying one or two areas where you could have supported yourself or your child in a more effective way.
- **When you anticipate using the PEACE process**, plan out your preparation for each step.
- **Celebrate** ANY success in any stage of the PEACE process.
- **Incorporate your family values into your daily life:** post them around your home, have frequent conversations about them, invite your family members to reflect on how they are modeling the values.
- **Make a plan** to revisit your family values as your children grow and your priorities shift.
- **Keep practicing the PEACE process**, even when it seems unsuccessful. Practicing and reflecting builds your skills.



References

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